(For some reason, by then Afzal had also changed his mind about Geelani and implicated him completely in the conspiracy.)

Each point of the ‘confession’ corresponded perfectly with the evidence that the police had already gathered. In other words, Afzal’s confessional statement slipped perfectly into the version that the police had already offered the press days ago, like Cinderella’s foot into the glass slipper. (If it were a film, you could say it was a screenplay, which came with its own box of props. Actually, as we know now, it *was* made into a film. Zee TV owes Afzal some royalty payments.)

Eventually, the Supreme Court set aside Afzal’s confession citing ‘lapses and violations of procedural safeguards’. But Afzal’s confession somehow survives as the phantom keystone in the prosecution’s case. And before it was technically and legally set aside, the confessional document had already served a major extra-legal purpose: On 21 December 2001, when the Government of India launched its war effort against Pakistan, it said it had ‘incontrovertible evidence’ of Pakistan’s involvement. Afzal’s confession was the only ‘proof’ of Pakistan’s involvement that the government had! Afzal’s confession. And the sticker-manifesto. Think about it. On the basis of this illegal confession extracted under torture, hundreds of thousands of soldiers were moved to the Pakistan border at huge cost to the public exchequer, and the subcontinent devolved into a game of nuclear brinkmanship in which the whole world was held hostage.

Big Whispered Question: Could it have been the other way around? Did the confession precipitate the war, or did the need for a war precipitate the need for the confession?

Later, when Afzal’s confession was set aside by the Supreme Court, all talk of Jaish-e-Mohammad and Lashkar-e-Toiba ceased. The only other link to Pakistan was the identity of the five dead fidayeen. Mohammad Afzal, still in police custody, identified them as Mohammed, Rana, Raja, Hamza and Haider. The Home Minister said they ‘looked like Pakistanis’, the police said they were Pakistanis, the trial court judge said they were Pakistanis. And there the matter rests. Had we been told that their names were Happy, Bouncy, Lucky, Jolly and Kidingamani from Scandinavia, we would have had to accept that too. We still don’t know who they really were, or where they were from. Is anyone curious? Doesn’t look like it. The high court said, ‘. . . identity of the five deceased thus stands established. Even otherwise it makes